ushman Bharat Pradhan Mantri Jan Arogya Yojana (AB-PMJAY), also implemented by the NHA, saw a 7.4 per cent increase in its budget over last year's revised estimates, but experts rue even this is not enough for proper implementation of the scheme. Ditto for the country's premier public health institute and hospital, AIIMS Delhi: it has received a 5.7 per cent increase in allocations as compared to the revised estimates for 2023-24, but experts say it's not nearly enough to support the growing demand in services at the central hospital.

Despite these concerns, not all is gloomy when it comes to budget for the health sector as a whole. There has also been a 14.13 per cent increase in the allocation for health research, with an allocation of Rs 3,301.73 crore for the Department of Health Research. The Indian Council of Medical Research (ICMR) received an allocation of Rs 2,732.13 crore, up from the estimated expenditure of Rs 2,295.12 crore in 2023-24. The National Tele Mental Health Programme also saw a rise in allocation, Rs 90 crore compared to last year's revised estimate of Rs 65 crore. "The Union budget also increased allocation for R&D, particularly through the Anusandhan National Research Foundation, a welcome step for the clinical research industry. This aligns with the sector's growing emphasis on innovation. The government's push for digital infrastructure under the Jan Vishwas Act will significantly enhance the operational efficiency of clinical trials," says Sanjay Vyas, executive vice president and managing director, Parexel, one of the world's largest clinical research organisations. The allocation of Rs 2,143 crore for the Production Linked Incentive (PLI) scheme for the pharma sector has also been welcomed by the industry. "These steps are vital for achieving our $5 trillion GDP goal in three years and $7 trillion by 2030," says Dr Saloni Wagh, director, Supriya Lifescience, a generic pharmaceutical company.

The doing away with custom duty for three cancer drugs—Trastuzumab Deruxtecan, Osimertinib, and Durvalumab, all manufactured by pharma giant AstraZeneca, and usually used for the treatment of lung or breast cancer—has garnered mixed reactions. On one hand, it is an attempt to bring cancer treatment in focus. "The high cost of cancer medications has been a major barrier for many patients, and this exemption will undoubtedly provide much-needed financial relief to those battling the disease," says D.S. Negi, CEO, Rajiv Gandhi Cancer Institute & Research Centre. However, public health experts say much more could have been done to make medicines affordable. "Some longstanding healthcare sector demands remain unaddressed in the current budget. These include prioritising healthcare as a national issue, promoting medical value travel in India, and rationalising GST with a uniform rate and full input tax credit eligibility," adds Dr Raghuvanshi. Overall the allocation for healthcare "pales into insignificance before the substantial allocations to defence and other priority sectors", rues Dr. B. S. Ajaikumar, executive chairman, HealthCare Global Enterprises. Whether the health ministry is able to allay the concerns by a judicious use of the funds remains to be seen. ■

